Everyone keeps talking about what Claude can do.

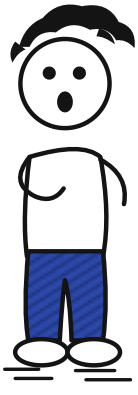
All I see is an empty text box.

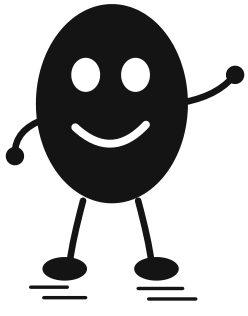


So what is Claude, then – a search engine?

No. A search engine gives you places to look. Claude gives you a **result**.

You describe what you need – Claude thinks, looks things up if it has to, calculates, writes, and puts the finished thing in front of you.





Search engine

Your question

↓

10 blue links

You read and build it yourself

Claude

Your goal

↓

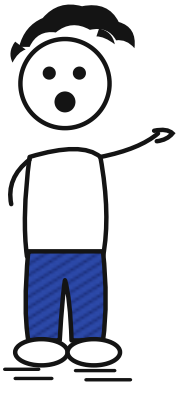
The finished result

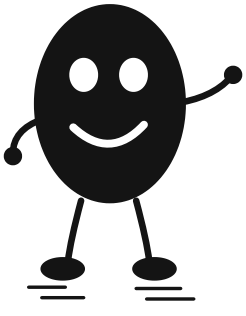
Text, spreadsheet, analysis, draft

And what do I have to install for that?

Nothing at all. Open a browser, sign in, start typing. There are apps for your computer and your phone too – but you need neither.

And you don't have to learn how to ask *properly*. Put it the way you would say it to a colleague.





Browser | Desktop app | Phone

↓

Good enough as a first message:

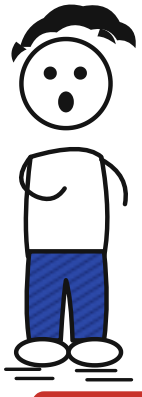
"I've got three quotes here for a new boiler. Tell me how they differ and what I should watch out for."

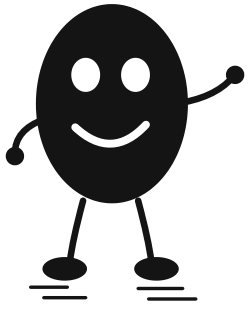
nothing to set up, nothing to learn

Can I give it my own documents as well?

Yes – just drag them into the conversation. PDFs, photos, spreadsheets, text files.

Claude reads them and works on from there: summarising, comparing, pulling out numbers, answering questions about them.



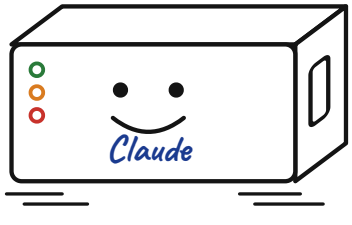


Quote.pdf

Photo.jpg

List.xlsx

Notes.txt



Summary

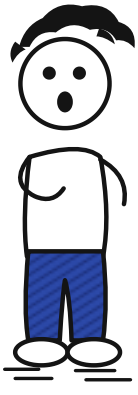
Comparison

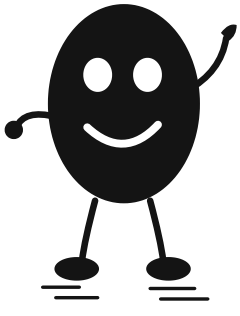
the numbers from it

Sometimes a window opens up on the right. What is that?

That is an **artifact**. When the result is no longer a sentence but a thing, Claude puts it beside the conversation instead of into it.

A document, an overview, a diagram – or a small application that actually runs.





In the conversation

- Answer
- Explanation
- Follow-up question

to read

As an artifact

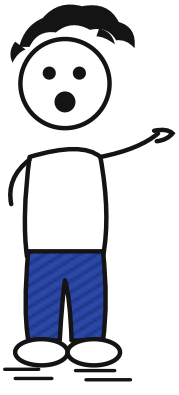
- Document
- Diagram
- Small application

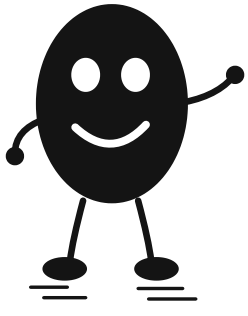
to use and to keep

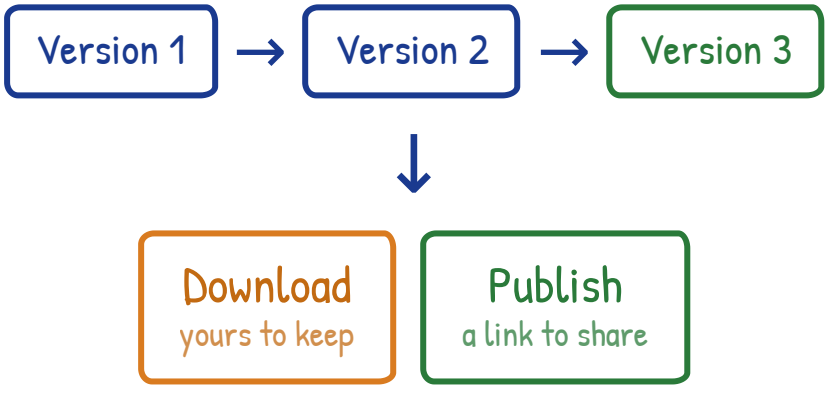
And what if I don't like something about it?

Say what should be different – Claude rebuilds it. You can also touch the text directly: highlight it and have it changed.

Every version is kept, so you can page back. You can download it, and publish it too: then you get a link to pass on.





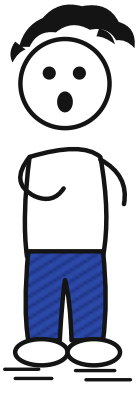


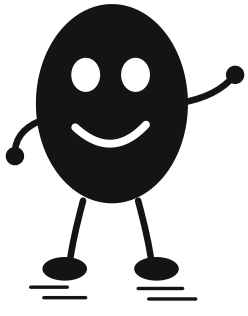
nothing is lost – you can always go back

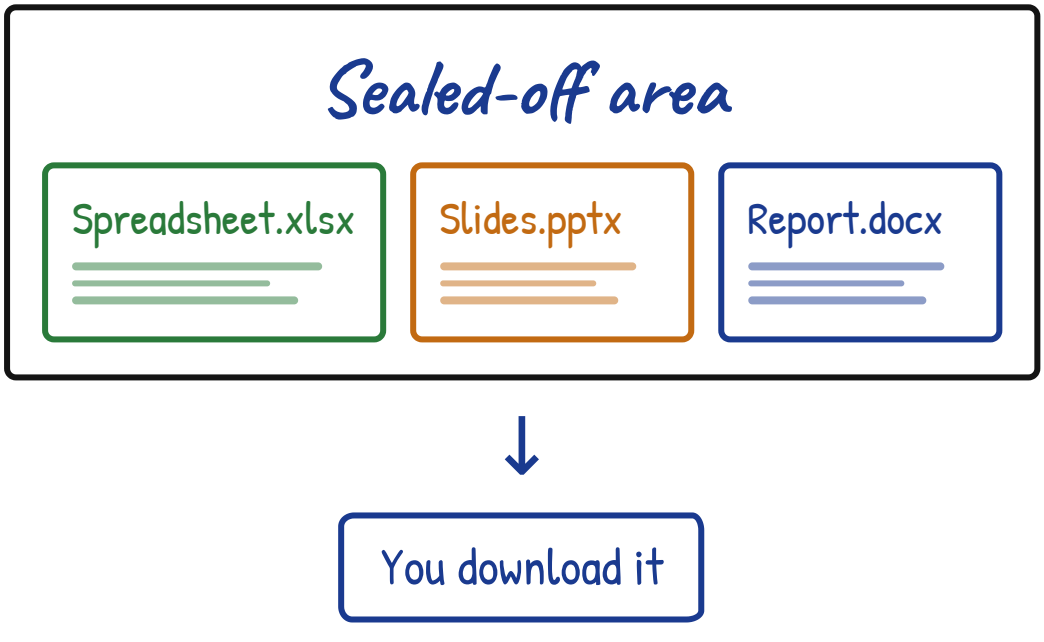
Do I get a real Excel file too?

Yes. Claude can build real files – spreadsheets with working formulas, presentations, documents, PDFs.

It is built in a sealed-off area at Anthropic, not on your computer. You download the finished file.





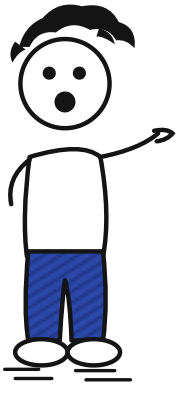


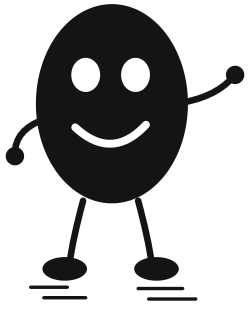
at this stage Claude cannot reach your own folders yet

And what if I need a proper document or slides?

Then just say so. Claude puts a **document**, a **slide deck** or a **design** next to the conversation – you keep changing it with Claude or directly yourself.

Documents can be edited by several people at once, slides come as PowerPoint or PDF. It works on every plan, including the free one.





Docs
write together

Slides
PowerPoint or PDF

Design
clickable drafts

↓

Change it with Claude

Edit it yourself

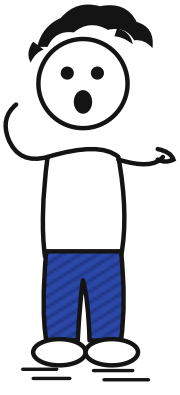
Link to share

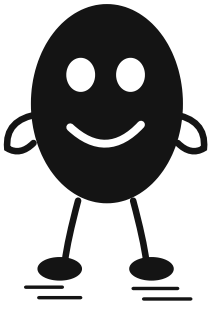
everything stays in the conversation – not in your folders

Should I put everything into one conversation?

Better not. A conversation has a working memory, and it fills up – then things get sluggish and vague.

Rule of thumb: new topic, new conversation. It costs nothing and makes the answers better.





All in one conversation

Holiday

Taxes

Application

Recipe

loses the thread

One topic each

Holiday

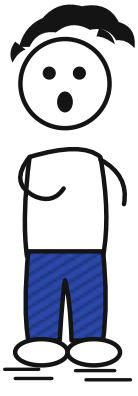
Taxes

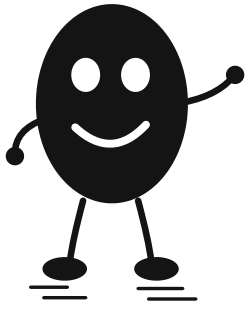
stays sharp

So do I start from scratch every time?

No. Claude remembers things across conversations and can look back at earlier ones. You can also just tell it "remember that".

What it remembered you can look at, change and delete – or switch memory off entirely. For one-off things there is incognito: it shows up nowhere.





What you like

What you work on

How you write

↓

Look at it

Change it

Delete it

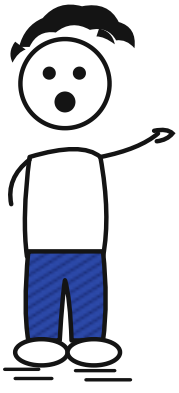
Switch it off

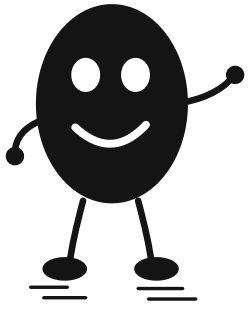
Incognito: no history, no memory, nothing stays

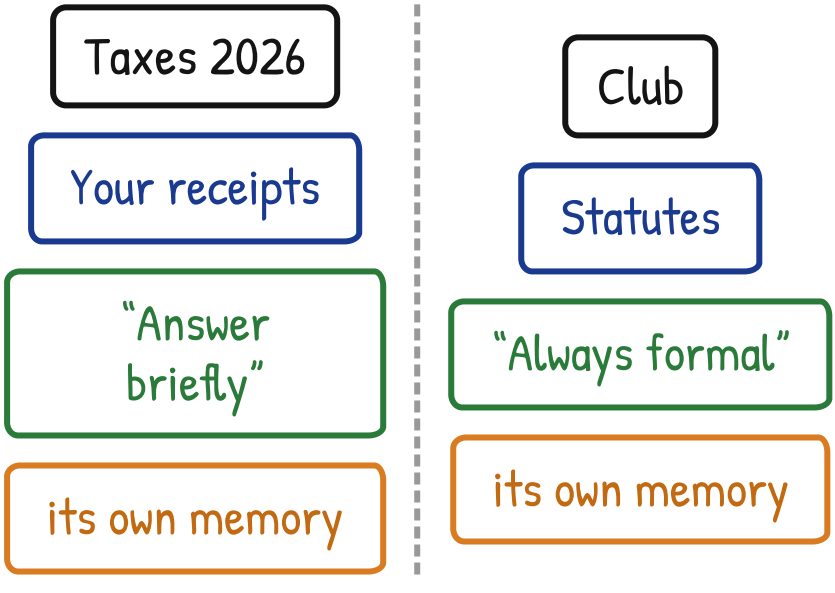
Can I bring some order to this?

That is what projects are for. Each one is its own workspace: its own conversations, its own documents, its own instructions – and its own memory.

Set it up once and it applies to everything inside. You don't have to explain the background again in every conversation.





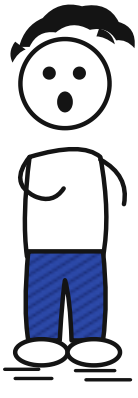


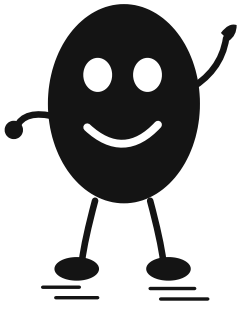
separate workspaces – nothing gets mixed up

Does Claude know what happened yesterday?

Not by itself – its knowledge has a cut-off date. But it can look things up, and then it names its sources.

Two different buttons: **search** briefly fetches something from outside. **Extended thinking** fetches nothing at all but thinks harder – good for puzzles.





Search

a quick look outside

with sources named

"What does that cost right now?"

Extended thinking

stays inside

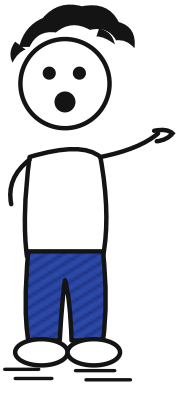
but goes deeper

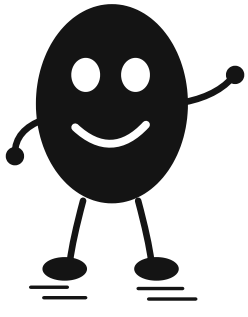
"Where is the mistake in my calculation?"

And if I want to know it properly?

Then use **Research**. Claude keeps searching on its own, follows leads and checks several sources against each other – usually for a few minutes, longer for big questions.

What comes out is a report with evidence, not a quick answer. For comparisons, market overviews, decision papers.





Your question → searches → reads → checks → Report

takes a few minutes

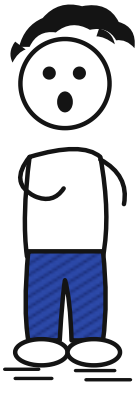
with sources you can look up

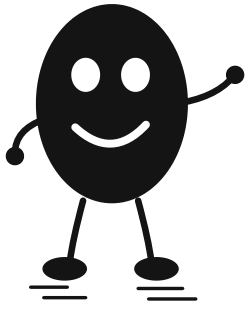
for the questions where a quick answer is no use

Can it get at my calendar and my mail?

If you connect it, yes. You attach Drive, calendar, mail and a good deal more under **Customize**.

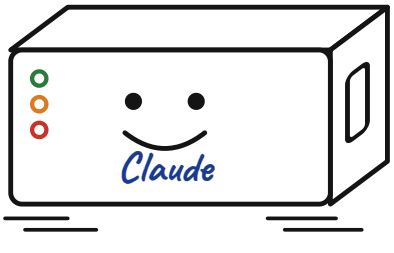
After that Claude fetches things itself. But only connect what you really need – and what you know.





Drive | Calendar | Mail | Slack

↓



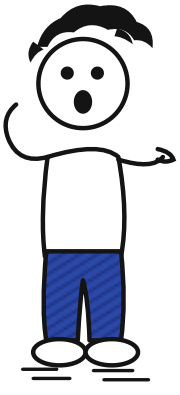
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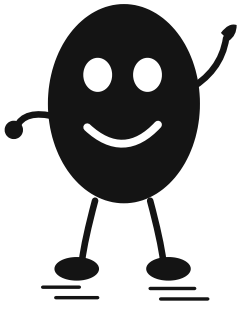
connect only what you need – Claude then sees what you see

It's always too long for me.

Then tell it – ideally once for all conversations: in the settings you note down how Claude should answer.

And for your own tone you build a skill from a few examples. Then you simply call it up.



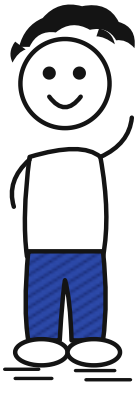


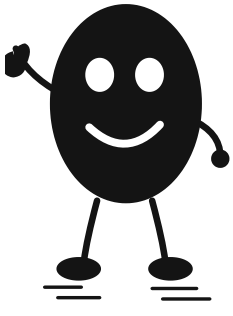
Settings	"Keep it short, no preamble" – applies everywhere
In the conversation	"Shorter, please" – applies from now on
Project	its own instructions for one workspace
Your own skill	sounds like you – built from your examples

And when I'm out?

The same conversation, everywhere: browser, desktop app, phone. You open it wherever you happen to be.

On the phone you can simply talk instead of typing. Handy while walking – and for sorting out your thoughts.





Browser | Desktop app | Phone

↓

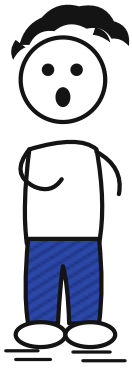
Typing | or simply talking

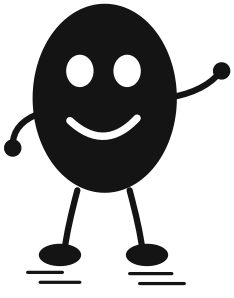
one conversation, wherever you open it

There's a name at the top. Do I have to change it?

Usually not. The default fits almost everything.

If a job is genuinely hard, take a stronger model. If it just has to be quick, take the small one. As of November 2026 they are called:





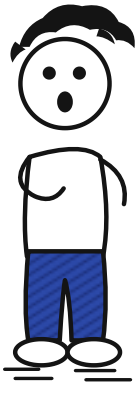
Fable 5.2	Opus 5.5	Sonnet 5.5	Haiku 5.5
the strongest	the heavy jobs	everyday work	fast & cheap
not on every plan	thinks thoroughly	the default	for short things

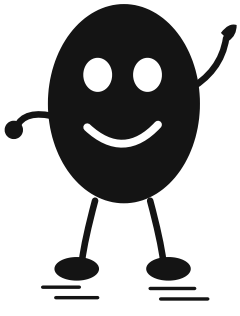
when in doubt: leave it alone

How do I best put it?

State the goal, not the steps – Claude finds the way itself. And say how you can tell when it is done.

Give the context: who it is for, what for, and what must not happen. The clearer the task, the fewer rounds.





rather not

"Write something about our summer party."

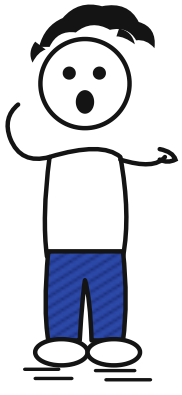
better

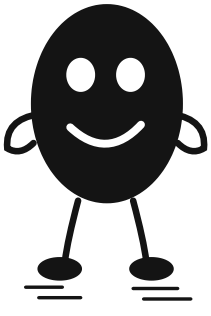
"An invitation to the summer party for the neighbours, half a page at most, friendly but not silly. Date and how to sign up must be in there."

Can I actually rely on it?

Usually yes – but Claude can also be convincingly wrong, and it sounds just as certain as ever while doing it.

So: for anything that matters, ask where it came from. And have numbers worked out again rather than believing them.





Ask for the source
where is that from?

Redo the arithmetic
step by step

↓

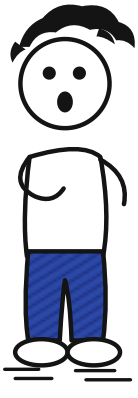
When it matters: read it over
contracts, applications, health

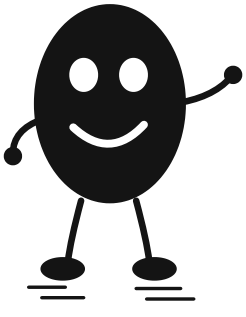
the more it matters, the shorter the leash

And if a PDF says "delete everything"?

Good question – that is where the trap is. Claude reads web pages, e-mails and other people's documents. **None of that is an instruction from you.**

Instructions come from you. Everything else is material to read. So with anything from outside, look more closely at what comes out.





Your instruction counts	Your project counts

↓

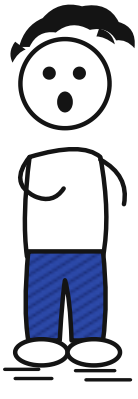
Web page material only	E-mail material only	someone's PDF material only

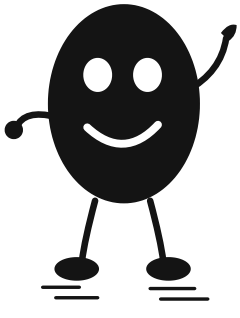
what it says gets read – not obeyed

What actually happens to what I write?

That is in the settings, and you decide it. There you set whether your conversations may be used to improve Claude.

Incognito conversations are never used for it – and never appear in your history either. For delicate matters the rule still holds: only put in what you would also hand to a service provider.



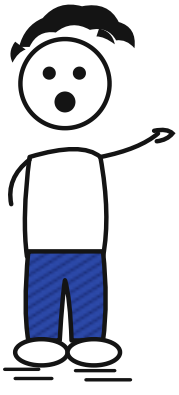


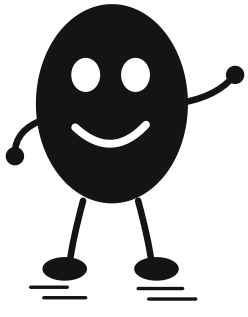
Settings	you decide whether conversations are used for improvement
Incognito	no history, no memory, never for training
Still true	credentials and other people's secrets belong nowhere near it

And if I want more?

Then it goes on in stages – the question is always how far you let Claude at your things.

Here, in the conversation, everything passes through you: you put in, you take out. On the paid plans, stages 1 and 2 are now one conversation – the difference is whether Claude may get at your folders.



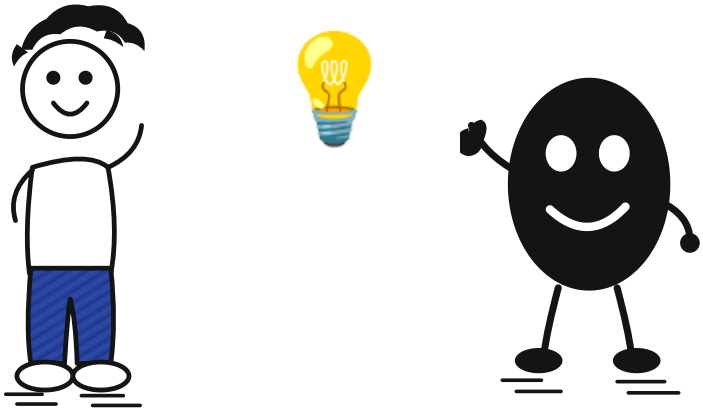


1 · In the conversation	nothing to set up – you upload, you download
2 · Letting it work	(formerly Cowork) in your folders
3 · Claude Code	terminal: Claude works on the whole machine – and keeps running without you

stages 2 and 3 each have a booklet of their own

Oh. That's not so bad after all.

Exactly. Start with a real job, not with a test.



Artifacts – Claude builds: docs, slides, designs
Files – drag them in, get real files back
Conversations – new topic, new conversation
Memory – it remembers things, and you can switch it off
Projects – separate workspaces with their own rules
Search & research – the quick grab and the long report
Connectors – Drive, calendar, mail under "Customize"
Style – say once how Claude should write
Asking well – state the goal, not the steps
Checking – sounding certain is not the same as being right
Outside content – it gets read, not obeyed
Keep learning – free courses at academy.claude.com
What's next – letting it work in your folders, Code for the whole machine